

WHICH AI SHOULD DO THIS?

Most teachers do not know there is a choice. Every AI tool offers **several models** — a careful slow one, a fast cheap one, sometimes three or four in between — and picking between them is treated as a technical decision. **It is not. It is a question about your classroom**, and there is one rule.

The rule, and the rest of this page is just applying it.

Match the model to who checks the output. If a student reads it and nobody else does, use the careful one. If you read it and can overrule it in two seconds, use the fast cheap one. That is the whole decision.

1

question that settles it, every
time

9

classroom jobs already sorted
for you

0

model names in the advice, on
purpose

Why no model is named in the advice

Model names change every few months and a printed list is wrong by spring. **The rule does not change**, and it works on whatever names your tool is showing you today. Page 4 tells you how to read the menu you have, whatever is on it.

Where this comes from

The software I run for my own high school woodshop course uses **two different models on purpose**, and the reason is written down in the code: the careful one writes anything a student will read, the fast one scores work that I read and can override. **That one sentence is the whole design decision**, and it is this page.

THE RULE

Who reads it, and can they catch it?

Not "which model is best." **Best at what, for whom, checked by whom.** Ask these two about any job before you pick anything.

1 • Who sees this output?

You, before anybody else? A student, directly? A parent? An administrator? **The further it travels without you in the middle, the more care it needs.**

2 • If it were wrong, would that get caught?

This is the one people skip, and it is the one that decides. A wrong score you glance at and change costs four seconds. **A wrong explanation a student reads alone and believes costs a week**, and you may never find out it happened.

So: **checked work can use the cheap fast model. Unchecked work cannot.**

And the third question, only when the first two tie

How much text is involved? A whole novel, a term's worth of notes, thirty essays at once — some models hold far more at once than others, and that is a separate axis from careful-versus-fast. If the job is large, check that before anything else, because a model that cannot hold the material will not do the job at any price.

Write the reason down, in one sentence, wherever you decided it.

Not for anybody else — for you in March, when somebody asks why the marking uses one thing and the study guides use another. **"A student reads this and nobody checks it, so it uses the careful one"** is a complete and defensible answer, and you will not reconstruct it from memory.

Nine classroom jobs, and which side they fall on

The job	Who checks it	Which model
An explanation a student reads on their own	Nobody	The careful one
Feedback sent straight to a student	Nobody	The careful one
A message that goes home to a parent	You, but it leaves the building	The careful one
Anything a colleague will present from	Them, without your context	The careful one
A first-draft score you review	You, every time	The fast cheap one
Sorting or tagging a pile of work	You, at a glance	The fast cheap one
Rewriting your own draft	You, obviously	The fast cheap one
Brainstorming, twenty ideas to pick three	You, by picking	The fast cheap one
Summarizing a long document you will read anyway	You	The fast cheap one

Notice what the pattern is not

It is not "important jobs get the good model." Scoring feels more important than brainstorming, and it is on the cheap side — **because you look at every score**. Importance is not the axis. **Being caught is the axis**.

The one that catches people out

Anything a student reads without you in between is the strictest case in the list, and it is the one most often done on autopilot with whatever was cheapest. A study guide, a hint, a worked example, a revision summary — if they read it alone and believe it, it needs the careful model and it needs you to have read it once.

How to tell which is which, without the names

Open the model list in whatever tool you use. **You are looking for three things**, and every provider publishes all three.

1 Price, which is the reliable signal

On the pricing page the models are listed with a rate each. **The most expensive is the careful one and the cheapest is the fast one**, and providers do not get that backwards. If you read nothing else, read the price order.

2 How much it can hold at once

Published as a context window or a token limit. **This is the axis that decides whether the job is possible at all**, separately from careful-versus-fast. A whole class set of essays is a lot of text.

3 Whether it thinks before it answers

Most tools now offer a slower mode that reasons first. **Worth it for anything with steps — grading against a rubric, working a problem —** and wasted on rewriting a sentence.

The chatbot version of the same decision

If you use a chat tool rather than something built, the dropdown at the top is this exact choice. **The rule is unchanged**: switching to the careful model costs you a few seconds of waiting, and it is worth it for anything a student will read and nobody will check. For rewriting your own newsletter, the fast one is fine and you will notice the difference in speed more than in quality.

One check that costs a minute and settles most arguments.

Run the *same* job through two models and read both answers side by side. **If you cannot tell them apart, use the cheap one** — that is a measurement, not a preference, and it is the only way to know for your subject and your students rather than in general.

YOUR TURN

Sort three of your own jobs

Pick three things you already use AI for, or are about to. **Fill in the middle column first** — it answers the third one for you.

Three jobs, sorted

The job	Who checks it before anyone acts on it?	Careful or fast?

Fill in the middle column first. It answers the third one for you, which is the whole point of the rule.

The one job on this page nobody checks, and what I will do about it

If your whole staff is making this choice by guessing

Our **ChatGPT & AI Prompting** staff training kit is the whole-staff version — deck with speaker notes, a word-for-word script, a participant handout and an administrator one-pager, presentable cold by somebody who has never run a session. Licenses are half price. Search our store for it.

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